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"THE WORLD'S IN FLAMES"

FOSSIL FREE YALE BRACES FOR TRUMP

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The Politic

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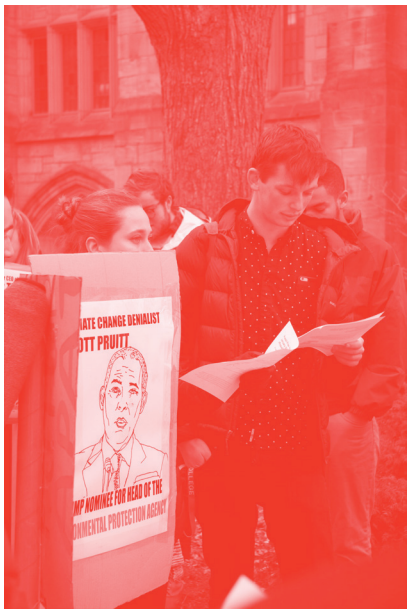

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FISHING FOR

"WHY IS NORTH KOREA SO CRAZY?" flashed word by word in bold letters at the beginning of a *Vox* video, titled "What made North Korea so bizarre?" While scrolling through Facebook, I paused at the video's bold title and bright colors. In two minutes, the piece interpreted one hundred years of North Korean history and stressed the importance of Japanese nationalism to understanding the nation today.

But it was the final slide that stuck with me: a cartoonish depiction of a jail cell with frightened eyes behind its bars. It could have been an image from a children's book or a Pixar movie. As the credits rolled, I closed the tab.

Vox is a source of news geared toward online consumers. The publication produces content for Facebook and Instagram, posting a mix of "explainer" articles, short videos with bold captions, and data-driven graphics.

Alvin Chang is a *Vox* graphics reporter whose work involves creating "cartoonxplainers" and diagrams to simplify complex issues for readers. Chang's recent work includes pieces like "What each incoming president thought was the biggest problem facing America, in one chart" and "A GOP congressman used an extended goat metaphor to criticize Obamacare. We illustrated it."

Though critics of *Vox* — such as Patrick Brennan of The National Review — accuse the site of "taking sides" in its explanations, Chang defended the mission of the site as one of reader empowerment.

"The question we ask ourselves," said Chang, "is how can we, as people who are good at taking in information and communicating it, be on the reader's side and advocate for them?"

"There are a lot of complex issues that end up affecting everyday Americans, but the deck is stacked against someone who, for instance, wants to understand what is going to happen to their healthcare through the Affordable Care Act," he explained.

Chang and his colleagues hope to include the average web user in the more sensitive debates of American politics. They frequently address race relations, income inequality and public policy using break-it-down lists or cartoons. *Vox*'s articles also tend

to make bold claims in their headlines like, "Trump's war isn't with the media. It's with facts." Statements like these can appear like facts instead of opinions, implying that to disagree with the *Vox* pundits is to sound misinformed. *Vox* reaches a large portion of its readership through social media sites, like Facebook.

According to the 2016 Pew Social Media Update, Facebook is the most heavily used social media platform for all adults, and the age group most likely to be active on the site is millenials (ages 18-30). Platforms like Facebook have changed the way individuals connect with the press and consume political news.

"Facebook tends to expose us to the kinds of information that the people we are connected to via social networks want to see," said R. Kelly Garrett, professor of communications at The Ohio State University, who studies emotions and social media. .

This means that users are frequently exposed to content liked and shared by friends — the majority of whom often share similar political leanings.

Lauren Lee '20, shared with *The Politic* how she uses Facebook to find content.

"I read a lot of opinion pieces or random articles I find that pop up on my feed," she said. As a political conservative, she said, "the ratio on my feed skews more toward conservative ideas."

Though most Facebook users tend to see political content that reaffirms their beliefs, much of a given user's news feed also includes sources that challenge their views.

In a study performed by Garrett and his colleagues at the Ohio State University Department of Communications, most Facebook users were exposed to stories that came from people they disagreed with based on their established ideology.

"A significant proportion — around 30 percent — of stories people interacted with were counter to their core beliefs," Garrett said.

Twitter has become another popular news source for people interested in keeping up with current events in real-time. Garrett compared different news sources in how they curate what users see.

"A search engine like Google will push us toward things that are popular, or highly cited. Twitter, however, will act like Facebook, in that it's all about who you choose to follow," he said.

The rising popularity of Facebook and Twitter as well as Instagram and Snapchat as news hubs has generated a demand for more user-friendly content. In an environment where ad revenues and exposure are determined by likes and shares, eye-catching clickbait and graphic-heavy blurbs compete for consumer attention.

"Our millennial generation is notorious for short attention spans, so it's great that the NowThis video style and other short pieces can keep people engaged who might not be otherwise," Jacob Bendicksen '20 told *The Politic*.

Bendicksen also noted possible shortcomings of simple, digestible news clips.

"But at the same time, a lot of this news is superficial," he said. "There is more to the key issues than a sixty-second video with some pithy captions."

Lee added that while she does consume high volumes of content on her Facebook newsfeed, she also visits outside sources for more in-depth coverage of important issues.

TRUTH

politics in the era of clickbait journalism

BY **MEGAN McQUEEN**

izenship through simplified media content," she said.

Robinson, himself an editor of a commentary and analysis publication, attested to the downsides of relying primarily on explainers like *Vox* for information.

"The dangerous thing about *Vox* is that they're all about simplifying the news. It's always, 'Here's all you need to know to understand big complicated issue X,'" Robinson said. "It's a noble role to try and educate the public," he acknowledged, "but instead of having people understand complexity, they're portraying the world as extremely simple, when it isn't a simple place at all."

The other downside to explainer news media is the bias that necessarily infuses such attractive content. Even where news is not blatantly false, headlines can mislead or distort the facts to fit a partisan model.

"*Vox* has blurred the distinction between journalism and commentary. Commentary is necessarily inflected with your political positions," Robinson said. "When you're doing analysis, you're not reporting the facts. You are interpreting the facts."

There is nothing wrong with political analysis. Popular pundits like Bill O'Reilly and Geraldo Rivera attract viewers because they interpret current events in a way people find interesting. They generate valuable conversations in the field of journalism and are distinct from field or investigative reporters. For example, Robinson's magazine, *Current Affairs*, deals primarily in analysis of political news, not original reporting.

"I am suspicious of *Vox* because they portray themselves as neutral explainers of the news," Robinson said, "instead of what they are — commentators. That's a great thing to be, but you have to acknowledge your role."

Vox is considered by many — including Ezra Klein, the company's founder — to lean center-left. Other content creators like Democracy Now! (short videos and live-streams) and The Other 98% lean even further left, according to the latest data collected by AllSides Bias Ratings. Despite these publications' detectable biases, Facebook and Internet users continue to like and share content produced by them.

"It's a funny thing, because I believe the news videos on my feed are trustworthy, even though they clearly have a spin," Bendicksen admitted. "They're never nonpartisan."

New alt-right sources also circulate widely on social media. These sources are known for producing inflammatory content. *Breitbart News* in particular has gained attention following President Donald Trump's nomination of Steve Bannon, one of the website's founders, as chief strategist and Senior Counselor. *Breitbart*'s website, as well as its Facebook and Twitter accounts, features posts with headlines like "You're too evil and stupid to know you're evil and stupid" or "There's no hiring bias against women in tech, they just suck at interviews."

From both sides, political discourse on social media sites tends to be partisan and sometimes openly hostile. According to a 2016 Pew Research study on the tone of political interactions on social media, most Democrats (65 percent) and Republicans (64 percent) find it stressful to talk politics on social media. The study also suggested that social media sites allowed people to discuss politics like they never would in person.

"We have really good evidence that Americans view one another with more distrust and more hostility when looking across political lines in general," Garrett said.

"There is evidence that with the advent of cable news, and the creation of Fox News in the mid-90s, there was a change in political discourse. CNN created an even more dramatic separation. Now there are huge differences between stories told on websites like *Breitbart* versus *the New York Times* or Alternet," he continued.

"People decide what to believe based on the emotions they are experiencing," said Garrett. "Those who are feeling angry are more likely to accept information regardless of whether it's accurate or not, if it affirms their political beliefs," he said.

Mike Isaac, a technology

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can now be believed which is seen in a newspaper

itself becomes suspicious by being put into that polluted vehicle

reporter for *The New York Times*, said that in this new, polarized media ecosystem, outlets have to look for ways to attract readers.

"A lot of folks look at watching or reading the news as something like eating your vegetables," Isaac told *The Politic*, "and it's not very fun — doesn't taste that good. I respect the idea that you can potentially package quality information into something more accessible. It's admirable, but I don't know that it's realistic."

To stay afloat in a market where shares and clicks are essential to raising ad revenue, *The Times* has made an effort to test new forms of content delivery. Some of *The Times*'s recent productions include "The Upshot," a data-driven blog addressing controversial issues, and "Daily Briefings," a subscription service that bring the most important news of the day to the inbox.

"We are starting to experiment," he said. "People respond very well to explainers. They may look silly, but some of them are reader-service oriented in terms of understanding how to break into a topic. We also do virtual reality and 360 degree video," he said.

When asked about the promise of *The Times*'s latest delivery strategies, Isaac responded with optimism.

"I don't think all of these things will work, and we will fail a lot, but that's a good thing. The fact that *The Times* is trying to do different things is a positive. When we find the things that work we will pursue them," Isaac said. "I'm a believer in the diversification of news sources."

While traditional sources like CNN or *The Times* may compete with independent media sites for visitors, there is a role for each kind of content in the news industry. And what *Vox* and its counterparts lack in complexity, they make up for in accessibility.

"If someone's first introduction to the war in Syria is through a *Vox* or NowThis video, my hope is that they could then dig into an investigative piece on *The Times* or elsewhere," said Isaac.

But the heated partisanship of the 2016 election has encouraged more users to share news from simplistic and, all too often, untrustworthy sources.

"From a social media platform's perspective, people are paying attention to what they are paying attention to, and it's not their role to sort out the truth," Nathan Robinson, editor of *Current Affairs* magazine, told *The Politic*.

Regardless of whether political polarization is a cause or consequence of the kind of content on newsfeeds, the way people engage with news is changing — and so is the consumer's responsibility in recognizing unreliable sources. Facebook and Google are taking steps to vet deceptive news sources on both of their platforms, though their success so far is unknown. And as more independent media companies produce seductive content that scratches only the surface of complex issues, it will be increasingly important that people explore more nuanced coverage from traditional publications.

After the election, Facebook in particular faced backlash for spreading misinformation. A November Buzzfeed article detailed how fake news pieces — most of which were anti-Clinton — outperformed real news leading up to the election. This outbreak of fake news evokes the "yellow journalism" of the early 20th century. But the internet and advent of simple web design tools have made it easier than ever to create viral and completely false stories that, at first glance, appear legitimate.

Debate about the relative merits of the modern press rages, and hysteria over the rise of fake news continues to grow. But this is no new phenomenon. From grocery-store tabloids that feed on a thirst for drama to Antebellum stories in which slaves were falsely accused of uprisings and violence, the press has long circulated mistruths — including those that serve a political agenda.

"Nothing can now be believed which is seen in a newspaper," Thomas Jefferson wrote over two hundred years ago. "Truth itself becomes suspicious by being put into that polluted vehicle."

— Thomas Jefferson

A SLICE OF NEW HAVEN

If you opened a 1960s "Student Guide to New Haven,"

YOU WOULDN'T FIND A SINGLE PIZZA RECOMMENDATION NEAR YALE.

Few restaurants were located near campus, even as New Haven's food scene blossomed. When Niki Papadopoulos opened Pizza House in 1963, on the day President John F. Kennedy was assassinated, his was one of the first eateries to cater to Yale students.

"Kids would line up down the street to get in," Niki's daughter and Pizza House's current owner Chris Papadopoulos reflected to *The Politic*.

Pizzerias have been around New Haven since Pepe's founding in 1925. For decades, their development tracked that of the Italian-American community, beginning on Wooster Street, nicknamed "pizza row." Eventually, they popped up in the Hill neighborhood, and then East Rock, tracing the path of Italian-American families. A 1989 guide to New Haven recommended Clark's Pizza, a Greek pizzeria up Whitney Avenue, and Naples, now Wall Street Pizza. These places marked the beginning of a saturated pizza market now surrounding Yale's campus.

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Tales of a crowded pizza market

BY **LEAH SMITH**

On a December morning, I visited Pizza House on the corner of Edgewood and Howe, a block behind Pierson College. Across from nondescript New England townhouses and a convenience store, Pizza House stands out with its bright red banner and neon lights that advertise its toasted grinders and founding year. Most of the seating inside is on stools at the long counter. I ordered a slice of cheese pizza. It was substantial, in every sense of the word — starting at the bottom, crispy in a deep-fried way, and supporting a puffy crust that almost leaked oil onto my hands. On top was a cooked and seasoned tomato sauce, and the whole thing was smothered in cheese that left a surprising tang in my mouth.

Two blocks away is Est Est Est Pizza, affectionately called "Est." You've probably walked by it, across the street from The Study at Yale. The outside is gleaming wood, and on weekend nights the interior is brightly visible through its huge windows. I asked to try their most popular pizza, and after some back-and-forth, men behind the counter offered me a slice with buffalo chicken and chunky blue cheese, covered in a heavy layer of buffalo sauce and mozzarella. The crust was New York style — not nearly thick enough to hold its weight, even when folded in half.

Empire Pizza's two star rating on Yelp made me dubious before I stepped in the door. The place is down Whalley Avenue, just before the Marriott Courtyard and easy to miss with its small storefront. I couldn't quite assign a style to the cheese pizza I ordered. The closest comparison I could think of was Papa John's — a thick, doughy crust, an abundance of cheese, and barely noticeable tomato sauce squished between. I asked one of the co-owners, Moh Ameg, what else he would recommend from the menu. He pointed me towards the Empire Bread, one of their specials. This was a twist on garlic bread: a fluffy toasted roll topped with freshly cut tomatoes, garlic spread, and cheese that didn't overwhelm everything else.

You wouldn't know it from the pizzas I tasted, but these three pizzerias have plenty in common: they were all founded by immigrant families; they all cater in part to the Yale students who have always been their customers; and they all sell pizza somewhat different from what we associate with "New Haven pizza" — charred crust, a chewy texture, and a sprinkle of pecorino romano.

Pizza House is off the beaten track for most Yale students. Today it serves mainly Yale employees, students living off-campus, and Chapel West neighborhood residents. When it first opened, the restaurant became an institution for Yale students, who played cards and studied in the restaurant, taking advantage of its late closing time at three in the morning. "The Sunday of graduation weekend, graduates and alums would bring their kids here" to see where they had studied, said Chris Papadopoulos. Niki had chosen to

THESE THREE PIZZERIAS HAVE PLENTY IN COMMON

they were all founded by immigrant families; they all c in part to the Yale students v have always been their custo and they all sell pizza somew different from what we asso with "New Haven pizza"

open a pizza restaurant in New Haven because, as Chris put it, "it just seemed like a good idea at the time."

"He was looking for an independent opportunity. He'd been working on a farm after coming from Greece in the early fifties, and he lived in Uncasville at the YMCA," Chris explained.

Pizza House was one of many pizzerias opened by Greek immigrants in New England at the time.

"Bill Captain was a man who helped to open several pan-style pizza, the first in this area," Chris said. One of those pizzerias was Est.

Another pizzeria opened by Greek immigrants in the area, Yorkside, was founded by the Koutroumanis family in 1977 after they had already opened other pizza restaurants in the area. These two — Pizza House and Yorkside — were part of a flood of Greek pizzerias and diners that emerged in New England after World War II. Thousands of Greek immigrants came to the United States, seeking an escape from the devastation of World War II and the Greek Civil War. Many started their own pizzerias or bought ones owned by retiring Italian-Americans.

In its early days, Pizza House only served a ten-inch pie on a brown 'papyrus' paper plates. Four small pizzas cost sixty cents each, and a fifth came free.

"Students would get the five pizzas, sell four, and keep the free one for themselves," Chris said. Today the prices have gone up and they sell by the slice, but they still adhere to a strict cash-only policy and make pizza the same way they've always done it.

"Start to finish, no shortcuts. It's labor intensive," Chris added. Every morning they proof the dough – letting it rise – and then refrigerate it, estimating how much they will need for the day.

"If we sell out of pizza, that's it," Chris said. The restaurant has also stayed in the family — Chris took over from her father and uncle, and her daughter now works there too.

But even if the pizza is the same, a lot has changed. In the late 1960s and 1970s, Yale students stopped making the walk to Howe Street. The Papadopoulos family pinpoints the turning point as the May Day protests of 1970, which they say led to Yale students staying closer to campus. The Chapel West district has changed, and struggled, since then.

"We stuck it out. Today the presence of the Yale community is getting stronger," Chris said, as more Yale employees move into the area. "Our neighborhood is a unique blend. When everyone comes together here, it's copacetic. There aren't too many places where that happens."

Both Est and Empire have benefitted from Yale students' return to off-campus eateries in the late 1990s. Ayman Gebril bought Est from its previous owner in 1996, about a decade after its establishment, and remodeled the restaurant completely. "I want this to be a friendly place for Yale students to hang out. They're good customers, and we never have any problems," he said.

The marketing has been effective, as has Est's proximity to late-night destinations.

"I ended up there because of its proximity to Sig Nu and convenient late-night hours, as well as the slices [being] displayed enticingly so that you can see them from the wintry streets of New Haven," Lucy Tomasso '19 said. "It has continued to serve as

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my late-night pizza place of choice."

"I chose to start a pizza shop in New Haven because I knew people around here liked it, even though there is competition," Gebril said.

Although he has worked in the pizza industry for more than twenty years, Gebril is also trained in classical French cuisine and graduated from culinary school in Egypt.

"I moved to the U.S. and realized that there is not much French cuisine here, so I learned how to make pizza myself," Gebril said. He has owned and operated several other restaurants in the New Haven area. Most recently, Est's popularity prompted him to launch a "Pizza Truck" that now caters events.

Empire, while still close to campus, is less frequented by students. Its clientele, as a result, skews more towards New Haven locals. The pizzeria has been around for fifteen years, but Moh Ameg has only been in the pizza business for two.

"The boss, Tarke Rage, he wanted to make pizza and Italian food, so he opened this up," Ameg said. Despite the competition, he said, "business is good. I've always worked with pizza, and this is nothing different."

With so many competitors, Est and Pizza House both rely the quality of their ingredients to set themselves apart.

"Quality is the one word I would use," Gebril said. "It has a personal touch. I am never stingy, I use the best cheese, and the best tomatoes, and I do it myself."

Freshness is the buzzword at Pizza House, too.

"We blend our own sauce, and use unique cheese, we get it in forty-pound blocks," Chris Papadopoulos said.

At Empire Pizza, Ameg shrugged at what made the pizza unique.

"It's Italian, homemade," was all he said. But he showed the menu to highlight their selection of grinders, burgers, spaghetti, and stuffed bread. During my time sitting in the restaurant, I did not see any customers order pizza. Instead, dishes like Empire Bread fuel the business.

"I try to make us more business by sending around menus, showing people all the food we have," Ameg said.

Pizza House relies on its decades-old legacy of serving the Yale community. The Papadopoulos family shared stories of how people bring visiting relatives there, to show off an authentic New Haven institution.

"We are to locals what Pepe's is to tourists," explained Zena Papadopoulos, Chris's daughter and the third generation working at the pizzeria. At Empire, Amag said that mailing menus, its reputation, and regular foot traffic brings enough business to keep the place going.

"It's not hard," Amag said. "Work is work, and everyone likes pizza."

IT'S NOT HARD. WORK IS WORK, AND EVERYONE LIKES PIZZA.

Between a ROCK and a HARD PLACE

A Small Public School Confronts Hate This Election Season.

BY **LILY MOORE-EISSENBERG**

Regarding Thomas and Leah: Their names have been changed to protect their privacy.

LAST FALL, in the small town of Harvard, Massachusetts, a video circulated among students. It flashed between the Twin Towers burning, masked ISIS operatives, and ninth grader Thomas' face. The soundtrack was reminiscent of an ISIS beheading video, described his mother, Leah, who immigrated to the United States from the Middle East. Back in September, Thomas' classmate and teammate made the montage, sending it to other students via Snapchat and text, until one recipient forwarded the video to Thomas. He showed his mother, who then reported it to the school and police.

Two months later, Harvard resident Robert Curran discovered a new coat of paint on the beloved town boulder while walking his dog through the town center. The rock, centrally located and traditionally painted by the senior class, is surrounded by only a handful of buildings in downtown area — the elementary school, high school, library, three churches, town hall, and general store. That morning, the rock was covered in swastikas, genitalia, and "Trump 2016."

The painted rock shocked the town as Harvard's public high school, Bromfield, joined the ranks of other secondary schools across the country plagued by racist graffiti in the weeks before and after the election. High schools from Atlanta to New Haven have reported incidents of hate activity within their hallways. And much of this vandalism — like the graffiti at Bromfield — explicitly mention Trump. In November, Swastikas and Trump references were found spray-painted at New Haven's Wilbur Cross High School. In December, the New Haven Islamic Center received a threatening letter addressed to "the children of Satan," calling Muslims "vile and filthy people," and claiming that their "day of reckoning has arrived" because "there's a new sheriff in town – Donald Trump."

In a recent national survey conducted by the Human Rights Campaign Foundation of over 50,000 teenagers, 70 percent reported having witnessed harassment, hate speech, or bullying since the election. According to the Southern Poverty Law Center (SPLC), the sharp rise in hate activity is correlated with Trump's campaign and subsequent win. The SPLC published a report titled "Ten Days After: Harassment and Intimidation in the Aftermath of the Election," which recorded hundreds of incidents – representing a marked increase in hate activity. The organization characterized this number as "a small fraction of the actual number of election-related hate incidents."

The line between hate speech and political statements started to blur during the last election season. Faced with politically-affiliated hate speech on school property, administrators and educators must decide whether to address political context or to avoid partisanship altogether. Superintendent Linda Dwight said she decided to separate hateful words from politics.

"We've tried to pull [the conversation] out of politics and talk about it as a moral issue," she said. "That [Trump's campaign] wasn't the offensive part. The rest of it was. So we tried to separate those two because we don't want to alienate the families that support Trump."

But the rise in hate speech and harassment calls into question whether it is possible to separate slurs from politics, and whether public schools — tasked with producing civically and morally-minded citizens — should try to do so.

Richard Hersh, a Yale lecturer who serves as Senior Advisor to the Education Studies program, argued that approaching the conversation from a moral standpoint does not preclude students and teachers from discussing issues that are often deemed political. Hersh has significant experience with education; before coming to Yale, he taught in suburban Boston public schools, headed the Center for Moral

Development at Harvard, and served as President of Hobart and William Smith Colleges and Trinity College.

"The school, whether it wants to be or not, is a moral educator," he said. "All the big societal issues are moral: inequality of income is a question of injustice, inequality of student performance in schools because of race and class disparity, the fairness of the tax system. Issues of justice are all moral questions, but people are so unused to talking about these issues in moral terms."

But is "moral" simply a less charged way of referring to the same debates? Or would a reframing of the issues really change the conversation? Right-wing outlets like Daily Wire and American Thinker have criticized the Democratic Party for having a "moral superiority complex." What happens when morality becomes as partisan as politics?

In Harvard, the moral approach has enabled community members to come together regardless of political affiliation. Instead of focusing on references to Trump scrawled on the rock, many townspeople have united under a general condemnation of bigotry through mission statements, coalitions, and committees. But Leah, Thomas' mother, does not feel that any of these conversations are genuine or productive because of what they have left out.

The incident, characterized in an email from the School Committee to parents of Bromfield students as "racially divisive," has not prompted further public discussion by the school or other community groups. On Nextdoor Harvard, a neighborhood social networking site, one user posted a comment in the rock graffiti discussion thread: "There was the school incident not long ago that we school parents heard about via email, but that was never detailed, leaving us to wonder who the targets were." Small town gossip on Nextdoor did not bring the events into focus. After interviewing teachers, students, parents, and community leaders, it became clear that very few people knew what had happened.

Bromfield psychology teacher Kathleen Doherty surveyed her students following a schoolwide assembly about the graffiti, asking them to describe how they felt about the vandalism and the administration's immediate response. Their reviews were mixed, generally divided into two camps: some students felt the school and community overreacted, feeding into the vandals' hunger for attention. Others felt that outrage was warranted and expressed frustration that many of their peers did not feel the same.

The defacement of the rock has come to symbolize intolerance in Harvard. But for Leah, the school's emphasis on what happened to the rock rather than what happened to her son seems backward and disingenuous.

"The rock is the second incident," she said. "Let's focus on the incident with people. None of these discussions are real. It wouldn't make me angry if they were real discussions."

Leah's words raise questions about how communities confront prejudice, what constitutes a genuine and productive discussion, and whether it is possible to have one without transparency. Summarizing her son's words on the subject, she said, "It's just a stupid rock. I'm a human being."

When hate becomes this personal, this deliberate, and this extreme, school administrators face a dilemma. According to Leah, Principal Scott Hoffman expressed frustration that the Bromfield Handbook — a compilation of school rules and a disciplinary guide — did not contain any clauses pertaining specifically to incidents like this one; it was not comprehensive enough to offer a clear, appropriate course of action. For public schools, rulebooks like the Handbook offer some leeway for disciplinary decisions short of expulsion. But if the contents do not cover the specifics of the incident, administrators face the difficult task of justifying their decisions adequately in the absence of pre-existing protocol, especially if the perpetrator's family applies legal pressure.

Leah has always wanted the story to go public, including names and details. But when a minor is brought to court for delinquency, all records pertaining to the case are confidential to protect the rights of children and families, including the perpetrator. To what extent the school is duty-bound

Photo Credits: Brian Johnson

"Most of it isn't swastikas on notebooks. It's using the term 'gay' as an insult, it's stereotyping a whole group based on misinformation, it's shunning people that are different."

to protect the student who made the video, even at the cost of doing a disservice to the victim, is contested. Dwight maintained that revealing any details whatsoever would compromise confidentiality, which would violate the Family Educational Rights and Privacy Act. Hersh affirmed that when a student's privacy is at stake, "legally [administrators'] hands may be tied."

Yet one might argue that premeditated hate speech targeting a specific individual is exactly the kind that must be discussed. When asked about bigotry among students, Dwight characterized prejudice and discrimination in the school as mostly subtle.

"Most of it isn't swastikas on notebooks. It's using the term 'gay' as an insult, it's stereotyping a whole group based on misinformation, it's shunning people that are different. We are trying to call that out and say that's not okay." She made no mention of anything more extreme than microaggressions and graffiti.

On Nextdoor Harvard, one user argued that political debates "should be had at the soccer fields and the transfer station," and that "this [responding to the graffiti on the rock] is about community, a community for all of us."

But for Leah, even supportive online forums aren't enough. She is still looking for a "real conversation."

Given the administration's legal duty to protect the privacy of students, the responsibility may fall to outside groups — perhaps the various committees and coalitions that have been formed in response to the rock. Leah is confident that the community will find out eventually what happened. But in the meantime, she worries about the lack of awareness, acknowledgement, and discussion surrounding what happened to her son and how the administration handled it publicly and privately. When the incident affected Thomas academically, teachers had not been told enough to know why he was suddenly struggling.

As Thomas continues to deal with the fallout of the incident, Leah struggles with her inability to galvanize a public response and show her son that his community supports him. Meanwhile, educators and administrators work to turn hateful incidents into teaching moments, but partisan politics and privacy issues often complicate their efforts.

Despite the apparent correlation between hate activity and the election, Hersh rejected the idea that Trump was the sole cause of the increase, commenting: "Trump is really in some sense one of the manifestations of it and one of the outgrowths of a country that has become coarse. He's not the cause of it; he's a caricature." But ultimately, moral education is not solely the domain of schools. In Hersh's words: "Public figures are always a form of teacher."

MULTIPLE CHOICE

THE FUTURE OF EDUCATION POLICY UNDER TRUMP

BY **ALBIN QUAN**

PARENTS DROP OFF THEIR CHILDREN ON THE SIDEWALK. TEACHERS WALK TO THEIR CLASSROOMS. STUDENTS MINGLE IN THE CHILLY MORNING, WAITING FOR THEIR SEVEN-HOUR SCHOOL DAY TO BEGIN.

This scene could be from any traditional American high school. But it's not. This school has only four hundred students. Its classrooms are in portable buildings lined up like mobile homes. Most schoolwork takes place on laptops through an online platform called the Personalized Learning Plan (PLP). This is Summit Rainier, a public charter school in the Alum Rock neighborhood of San Jose, California. And it is part of a growing nationwide trend towards charter schools.

For fifty years, several politicians and education officials—now represented by President Donald Trump and his Secretary of Education nominee Betsy DeVos—have promised to fix America's public school system and make the country a world leader in academic performance. Charter schools in particular have been promoted as better suited to focus on student outcomes than public schools, since they are less constrained by oversight and regulations.

In many ways, Summit Rainier represents a key question for school choice advocates: Can charter schools consistently provide all students with a better education? Proponents argue that by giving schools like Rainier

more autonomy and flexibility, they can compete with publicly funded schools while providing alternative options to families living in districts with high dropout rates and low test scores. But critics assert that charters drain government resources that could otherwise go towards improving public schools and lack the accountability measures to ensure money is not wasted on failed programs.

In 2011, a group of committed parents from East San Jose helped found Rainier to address the lack of schooling options in the area for their children. According to Jesse Roe, Executive Director of Rainier, his school is now one of 12 non-magnet charter schools in the East Side Union High School District. Yet within this district alone, charter schools vary tremendously in college acceptance rates, curricula, and demographics.

While all these charter schools aim to better prepare students for college and provide an education comparable to that offered by public schools, each has a specific focus. Roe describes Rainier's mission as a three-part approach that promotes a diverse student body, prioritizes college admissions, and creates productive members of society.

For students who attend Rainier, this mission has created a community where students feel more comfortable than they would in a traditional public school. Austin Zhen is a senior at Summit Rainier who transferred from a public high school.

"At my old school, Piedmont Hills High School, I really didn't like the class size. I felt like I didn't get enough attention, one-on-one attention. I felt like I didn't know my teachers and my peers didn't know me," he said in an interview with *The Politic*.

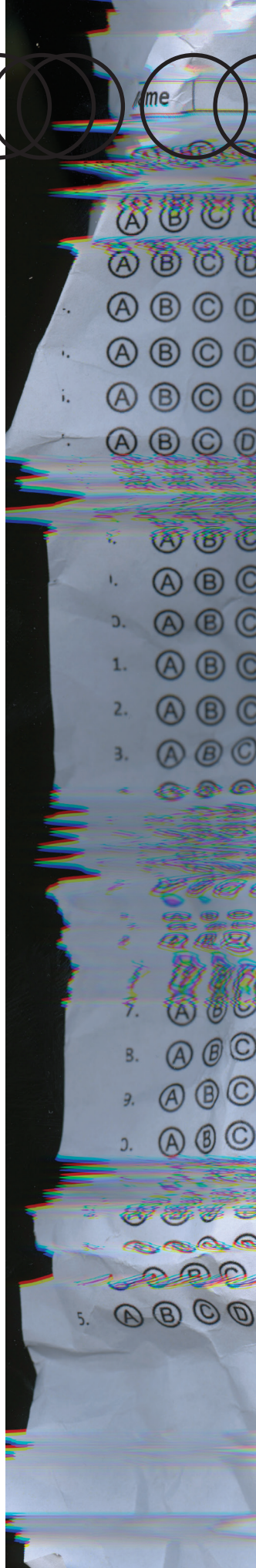
Idris Alexander, another senior, shared a similar experience transitioning from public high school to Rainier.

"Here at Summit, I feel a lot closer to everyone on campus whereas at public school, it was very distant," he explained. Roe attributes this sense of community to Rainier's small enrollment size and the relationships between parents, students, and the school administration.

Rainier provides individual attention to students by using technology that measures students' progress through month-long projects and quizzes called content assessments. Teachers can then focus lessons to benefit the most students while providing challenging material to those who work ahead. The online platform was the result of a collaboration between Facebook and the Summit Public Schools charter network, Rainier's parent organization, that focused on developing a personalized model to address individual learning while documenting students' growth

TRUMP CALLED THE CURRENT PUBLIC SCHOOL SYSTEM A "GOVERNMENT-RUN EDUCATION MONOPOLY."

The results, however, have been mixed. According to a 2015 assessment, only 50 percent and 25 percent



of Rainier juniors are proficient in English and mathematics, respectively. These numbers are comparable to those of Mt. Pleasant High School, a public school whose campus is shared with Rainier's. However, Rainier has achieved 100 percent graduation rates for the past two years.

While Rainier's charter reform measures represent only a small subset of the many tactics tried across the nation, it is unclear how scalable they will be given the varied needs of different local communities.

The school choice movement gained became a national force in the early 1990s when Minnesota and California passed school choice laws and President Bill Clinton LAW '73 took office. His administration oversaw an unprecedented expansion of charter schools across America with the passage of the Charter School Expansion Act in 1998.

This growth of charter schools continued under the administration of President George W. Bush '68. The landmark No Child Left Behind Act allowed schools that had "failed" for six years to be closed down or converted to charter schools. According to the National Center for Education Statistics, the number of charters nationwide grew from 1,993 in 2001 to 4,388 charter schools in 2008. The Summit Public School charter system was part of this exponential growth—its first school opened in 2003 in Redwood City.

PUBLIC SCHOOL ADVOCATES BELIEVE DEVOS WILL PROMOTE DANGEROUS, ILL-CONCEIVED EDUCATIONAL PRACTICES DESIGNED TO CREATE CORPORATE PROFITS

President Barack Obama's administration continued to expand the funding available to the Federal Charter School program, increasing the program's budget by over $100 million over seven years. Summit schools expanded along with this funding. They now operate nine schools along the West Coast.

President Obama's tenure saw an uptick in charter school enrollment. The number of students attending charter schools jumped from 1.6 to 2.5 million, a change from three percent to six percent of the U.S. public school student population. This proliferation of charter schools has made charters more accessible to students across the country. At least three of Summit's schools operate in low-income or working-class neighborhoods. Their student populations are intentionally diversified by race and income levels, matched to the neighborhoods they are in.

If his campaign rhetoric is any sign, President Trump will oversee a further expansion of charter schools like Summit.

In a speech delivered in Ohio in September, Trump called the current public school system a "government-run education monopoly."

"The Democratic Party has trapped millions of African-American and Hispanic youth in failing government schools that deny them the opportunity to join the ladder of American success," Trump said. These statements reflect longstanding claims of school choice advocates, who have blamed teachers unions and government bureaucracy as the main reason for dismal educational outcomes and unprepared students.

Trump has called for a $20 billion block grant for states with charter schools and private school voucher programs, to be funded by "reprioritizing existing federal dollars." With no discussion of accountability or standards, it is unclear how a Trump administration will measure educational outcomes, nor is it clear which other federal programs will be rolled back to provide funding for his proposal.

It is also not clear that charter schools will provide better educational outcomes for the students they serve. In the Summit system, for example, while over 90 percent of its graduating classes are consistently accepted into four-year colleges, only 55 percent of its first graduating class was on track to graduate college within six years. According to Summit's co-founder and CEO Diane Tavenner, this disparity forced a complete retooling of the school's educational practices.

"Literally everything had to change," she said in an interview with U.S. News & World Report. These changes began to be implemented in the 2011–12 school year—eight years after the first Summit school opened.

Trump's nominee for Secretary of Education, Betsy DeVos, is a well-known philanthropist and advocate for charter schools, school vouchers, and other school-choice initiatives. In many ways, her proposals and beliefs seem to align with, and even expand on, the policies of previous administrations in the last three decades that have called for educational options beyond public schools. For critics of school choice and the so-called "privatization" of education, DeVos will be a lightning rod. Public school

advocates believe she will promote dangerous, ill-conceived educational practices designed to increase corporate profits at the expense of students.

Aside from school choice, DeVos has no track record on other issues of concern to educators, as she has no experience working in or for public schools. During her confirmation hearing, she appeared confused about the difference between the terms "growth" and "proficiency" when responding to a question from Senator Al Franken (D-MN).

Later, when Senator Tim Kaine (D-VA) asked, "Do you think K-12 schools that receive federal funding should meet the same accountability standards, outcome standards?", DeVos responded that she supported accountability without giving any definition for that term.

Kaine followed up with a question on the Individuals With Disabilities Education Act, asking whether it should apply to all schools that receive federal funding. DeVos responded, "I think that is a matter that's best left to the states." This has led to concern that a DeVos-run Department of Education would not enforce long-standing disability protections established by the federal government.

As heiress to a large family fortune, DeVos – along with her husband, the billionaire founder of Amway – has contributed money to efforts aimed at expanding school voucher programs across the country and lobbying for charter school access in states that had previously banned them. These actions have led to concerns that she might have significant conflicts of interest. During DeVos' confirmation hearing, her assets were the subject of intense scrutiny, especially after the revelation that the Office of Government Ethics had not been able to complete a full review of her financial disclosures.

If she is confirmed by the Senate, DeVos' tenure is likely to accelerate the long-term trend towards charter schools and private voucher programs while weakening existing education standards and accountability measures. With an aggressive pro-charter push by the Trump administration and a Republican-controlled Congress, individual states will likely respond to the proposed incentives and grants by increasing school choice. Such programs will provide more options for students, though the merits of these options remain contentious.

With increased autonomy and lax standards, school districts will face tough choices about dividing their federal and state dollars between public and charter schools. But support does not equal success. The continued operation and expansion of charters like Summit Rainier will require significant planning and forethought.

"It takes a lot of work. It takes a lot of coordination," said Roe. "Each school has its own identity. And each school has its own culture."

But given the Trump administration's tendency for confrontation and the potential for an aggressively hands-off Education Department, Roe acknowledged that "there will be a backlash for increasing school choice." The fight over school choice may have no end in sight, but the new administration will probably tip the balance further in favor of charter schools. It may not be until the start of the next school year that it becomes clear where this decision leaves students.

the sea will rise

but so will we

we will fight

just wait and see

"THE

the world's in flames

and it's rex to blame

when the oil spills

won't be rex it kills

it'll take its toll

on the people whose futures he stole

only we can stop it

yale, will you profit?

the sea will rise

WORLD'S IN FLAMES"

Fossil Free Yale Braces for Trump

BY SARAH AL-SHALASH

"IF ANYONE WANTS TO BE ON FACEBOOK LIVE, SMILE big at my right nipple because that's where I'm putting the camera," a student in Fossil Free Yale (FFY) announces to the group as he tucks a phone into the front pocket of his shirt.

The student prepares to live stream the protest to the FFY Facebook page, disregarding strict rules against photography in Woodbridge Hall, the building that houses the Yale President's Office. He is one of about 20 people gathered to get the attention of Yale's administration. Among the group are students, graduate students, and two faculty members: Mary Evelyn Tucker, a Senior Lecturer and Research Scholar at Yale, and Robert Dubrow, Professor of Epidemiology at the Yale School of Public Health. As the group gets ready to enter the building, more students approach.

The day of the protest, January 23, marks the start of a national call for action by 350.org, and its subsidiary, the Fossil Free movement, called #Resistrejectdenial. It is 350.org's campaign to resist and reject the climate change denial they see in the Trump administration. Across the country, over a thousand students at schools like Boston University, the University of Denver, and Oregon State University stage walkouts in what they anticipate to be the first of many resistance movements.

This Fossil Free Yale protest is relatively small.

"It's shopping period. We didn't even make a Facebook event for this, we didn't need it to be big. We just wanted to demonstrate solidarity with the national movement," Rachel Calnek-Sugin '19, a core FFY member, tells *The Politic*.

The students march into Woodbridge Hall, calling out for President Peter Salovey and carrying signs with the faces of President Donald Trump's nominees: Rex Tillerson for Secretary of State, Rick Perry for Secretary of Energy, and Scott Pruitt as head of the Environmental Protection Agency (EPA). Pilar Montalvo, Director of Administrative Affairs at Woodbridge Hall, rushes to intercept the activists. She tells them President Salovey is in a meeting.

Unfazed, the students insist on "leaving a message" for him. "Handing over our government to the fossil fuel industry will only add gasoline to the fire," Tucker reads aloud in the lobby. "As John Simon wrote, ordinary action is no longer sufficient to put out the flames. It's time for Yale to take moral leadership and divest," she continues.

After ten minutes of speeches, Montalvo ushers them out. "Thank you for stopping by," she says. Then, after a tense pause: "and thank you for now...going."

The students file out one by one, singing in unison.

The sea will rise
But so will we
We will fight
Just wait and see

The world's in flames
And it's Rex to blame
When the oil spills
Won't be Rex it kills

SINCE TRUMP'S ELECTION VICTORY, FFY has declared a "world in flames" scenario. The protests were made more urgent by the Yale Corporation's upcoming meeting, when they are scheduled to vote on divestment from ExxonMobil.

Trump's nominees were at the center of the most recent protest. FFY members said in their speeches that Rex Tillerson, former CEO of ExxonMobil, actively spread misinformation about global warming, that Scott Pruitt,

Some have questioned whether the divestme campaign's symbolic victories are the right k victories to chase.

as former attorney general of Oklahoma, sued the EPA 14 times, and that Rick Perry, former Texas governor and "climate change denialist," sits on the board of the company spearheading the Dakota Access Pipeline and once forgot, during a 2011 presidential debate, the name of the department he has been nominated to run.

Yale's Fossil Free movement has protested the university's ties to fossil fuel companies with mixed success since it started in the fall of 2012. In August 2014, the Yale Corporation rejected FFY's initial proposal for divestment. But FFY has maintained an active presence on campus. In April 2015, FFY staged a protest at Woodbridge Hall, ending with 150 students in a human chain around the building and nineteen students arrested for refusing to leave the premises. A year later, the organization staged a silent protest at the keynote address of United Nations Secretary General Ban Ki-moon, holding signs that said, "UN supports divestment. Universities: When will you?" That same day, the Yale Investment Office's Chief Investment Officer David Swensen wrote a letter stating that $10 million of Yale's endowment had been removed from three publicly traded fossil fuel companies.

That commitment made Yale one of 82 educational institutions listed on the the umbrella Fossil Free organization as having divested. But the news did not come without criticism, especially from the Fossil Free movement itself. In a post on its website in response, FFY cites the announcement as a "victory, but a limited one," because the move "didn't reflect any commitment to divestment on the part of the university, just the individual actions of two outside fund managers."

"Yale's announcement last year that it removed $10 million [from] two fossil fuel companies (thermal coal and tar sands) on purely economic grounds was an exciting step for our campaign but it was not divestment," said Chelsea Watson '17, who handles communications at FFY, in an email to *The Politic*.

The group took up two main issues with Swensen's announcement: First, that the university committed only to partial divestment, and second, that the decision was not based on ethical reasons.

"This partial divestment was done not because of concerns about racial justice or climate justice, but because Yale investors, as usual, are most concerned with their bottom line," the post reads. "We remain committed to winning binding, comprehensive, and morally unambiguous divestment from the fossil fuel industry, and the Yale Corporation remains committed to being opaque, inaccessible, and putting profit over people," it continued.

Some have questioned whether the divestment campaign's symbolic victories are the right ones to chase.

In his 2014 article "Divestment is No Substitute for Real Action on Climate Change," Harvard professor Robert Stavins argued that involvement in the divestment movement costs time — time that could be better used working towards more tangible goals.

"A major problem is that symbolic actions often substitute for truly effective actions by allowing us to fool ourselves into thinking we are doing something meaningful about a problem when we are not," he writes.

The global Fossil Free movement is one of the fastest growing and most influential climate activist organizations in the world. Its founder, Bill McKibben, a journalist and college professor turned activist, is used to criticism. In an interview with *The Politic*, he argued that the impact of the Fossil Free movement is not just symbolic.

"I think it's eminently practical," he said.

McKibben founded 350.org, a grassroots climate change campaign that aims to create a global movement, and organized a new divestment movement inspired by efforts to divest from South African companies to end apartheid. This time around, McKibben and fellow activists work to pressure major institutions and universities to divest from the fossil fuel industry.

Gofossilfree.org cites 649 institutions, worth $5.44 trillion, that have committed to divestment. Notable among those that have divested are the Norwegian Sovereign Wealth Fund – the richest sovereign wealth fund in the world – the Rockefeller Brothers Fund, and Yale University.

Yale is one of many institutions that have only partially divested. Stanford, also on the list, has agreed to divest only from its holdings in coal. Other universities that have partially divested include Georgetown, Oxford, and Cambridge.

And other universities have refused to divest altogether.

In October 2013, Harvard University President Drew Faust rejected a proposal from members of the college's fossil free movement to divest from fossil fuels.

"The endowment provides more than one-third of the funds we expend on University activities each year. Its strength and growth are crucial to our institution-

nt
kinds of

al ambitions — to the support we can offer students and faculty, to the intellectual opportunities we can provide, to the research we can advance," the letter states.

Daniel Kammen, climate Science Envoy for the State Department and professor at UC Berkeley, says that financial concerns discourage divestment.

"Many institutions, universities and others might not want to divest because they believe it's going to cost them money," he said in an interview with *The Politic*.

In a 2014 article, Kammen and Charles Greene, professor of earth and atmospheric sciences at Cornell University, argue that divestment is financially wise.

"What we wanted to argue was remaining invested in fossil fuels was in fact not a very sound financial decision," said Greene. "The business models that these companies follow are not going to pay off in the longer term."

Kammen echoed this thought. "There are lots of things that look like a short term cost, but remove high risk items from your portfolio, and so ultimately are good things to do financially as well as socially and environmentally," he said.

McKibben thinks that this argument is beginning to gain traction.

"Four years ago, it was a fringe idea that we had far more carbon in our reserves than we could ever burn. Now it's the standard assessment of the financial world," he said.

FFY has based most of its arguments for divestment on moral obligations instead of financial concerns. The Fossil Free movement states that many of its goals revolve around ending fossil fuel companies' "social licence to operate," an ethically rather than financially motivated goal.

Watson talked about divestment as a kind of symbolic resistance with a moral dimension.

"The power of divestment, and this goes back to apartheid and tobacco divestment campaigns as well, comes from its symbolic power," she said. "The fossil fuel divestment movement stigmatizes the coal and petroleum industries, signaling a shift in public opinion and allowing for real political change."

Still, Stavins argued that those involved in the divestment movement have an opportunity cost to consider.

"Faculty, staff, and students all have limited time; indeed, as in many other professional settings, time is the scarcest of scarce resources. Giving more attention to one issue inevitably means — for some people — giving less time to another," he wrote.

Paul Sabin, a professor of environmental history at Yale and director of undergraduate studies for environmental studies, pointed out some alternative uses of that time.

"I do wonder sometimes whether it might be more politically effective for the divestment campaign to focus on state and federal regulatory issues, and organizing people around more direct political action, because this is more of a symbolic campaign than one that leads to a lasting impact on the regulatory landscape for energy," he said in an interview with *The Politic*.

Many people on the borders of Yale's campus feel the effects of climate change directly. Experts at New York University found that of all the counties in Connecticut, New Haven County records the highest annual mortality rate from air pollution, at 54.9 deaths per year.

Sabin noted the lack of organized environmental justice work in New Haven, on issues like air pollution and beyond, and its effects on low-income communities of color.

"I think it's interesting that there's no real coherent environmental justice organization and movement in the state of Connecticut."

By comparison, he said, "If you look at New York and Boston, you have grassroots organizing — communities of color and low-income groups have organized around transit justice, around clean air, shutting down power plants, opening up access to green spaces. More of a campaign for environmental equity."

Kammen also acknowledges that the inequity in focus of climate change movements is a problem, but does not think it has to be.

"[The fact that] the benefits of clean energy go first to the rich and later to the poor is a real problem. It's one of the reasons why a community like New Haven — or Yale in New Haven, that wants to both address climate change and wants to address social inequality, in my view and in the view of the scientific community, should see this as a really key overlap," he said.

In her response to the Harvard Fossil Free group, President Faust levelled a similar criticism at the divestment movement more broadly.

"Because I am deeply concerned about climate change, I also feel compelled to ask whether a focus on divestment does not in fact distract us from more effective measures, better aligned with our institutional capacities," she said.

"I guess I find that to be a really frustrating argument," said Watson in response to this notion. "Of course FFY takes a

"and it's RICK to blame

and it's SCOT to blame"

lot of time, but that's because it takes a lot of time and energy to make change."

Likewise, Calnek-Sugin thinks the campaigns for divestment and environmental justice don't need to be separated.

"I would say that fighting for fossil fuel divestment is the same as fighting for better air quality — that's the whole point, right?" she said.

"I spend most of my free time working on mitigating the cause and effects of climate change, and out of the many different routes I've taken, organizing through Fossil Free Yale has felt like the most important thing I can do right now to leverage my power and privilege as a Yale student," Watson said.

McKibben also defended the divestment movement.

"I've noticed that people who fight for divestment also have time and energy to fight for plenty of other things. I've actually never met someone who said 'I used the time I saved not fighting for divestment to go shut down a pipeline.' I think it's an entirely bogus argument used by the kind of weaselly people who never actually want to do very much," he said.

In an interview with *The Politic*, Elias Estabrook '16, a former FFY organizer and a current environmental organizer in New Haven, acknowledged the possible benefits of focusing on other environmental problems besides divestment. "There are certainly times where I thought about, you know, could I be out lobbying for carbon tax regulation?" he admitted.

But Estabrook ultimately believes divestment is worthwhile.

"I really do think it's a strategic tactic for students to be using their role, their position as constituents of the university, members of the Yale community, to put pressure on Yale as an investor to take action," he said.

Chris Schweitzer works with the New Haven Healthy City/Healthy Climate Challenge and previously led the New Environmental Justice Network.

"Divestment at this point in 2016 or 2017...it's a great question whether or not that's the best path to be on. But for me, almost anything happening to push people on climate change is a good thing," he said in an interview with *The Politic*.

He holds that the divestment movement might be the most useful and powerful political tool Yale students have, even if divestment is not the ultimate goal.

"When you're organizing, you don't necessarily pick a target that's the be-all end-all, you do it as a step towards a greater goal," he said.

"I just think that oftentimes it seems like social, political, environmental problems of the world are so immense that there's nothing that we can possibly do," Calnek-Sugin said. "When you're like 'how do we address the massive issue of climate change?' it's really useful to feel like you're working towards a defined goal."

Watson agreed.

"For the first time there is a global student movement that is matching the scale of the problem," she said.

"There's always this thing about critiquing groups doing organizing and should they be doing something better," Schweitzer said. Nevertheless, he continued, "Organizations and people often make choices based not on what's most effective but based on what's doable and what's possible."

Todd Stern, the United States Special Envoy for Climate Change under the Obama administration and a negotiator of the Paris Climate Accords, agreed.

"Insofar as college campuses and students on college campuses are active or are getting active or get more active on the imperative of dealing with climate change and reducing carbon emissions, I think that's great, and I think that's an important thing," he said. "The biggest variable for the capacity of the country and the world to deal successfully on climate change in my judgement is politics."

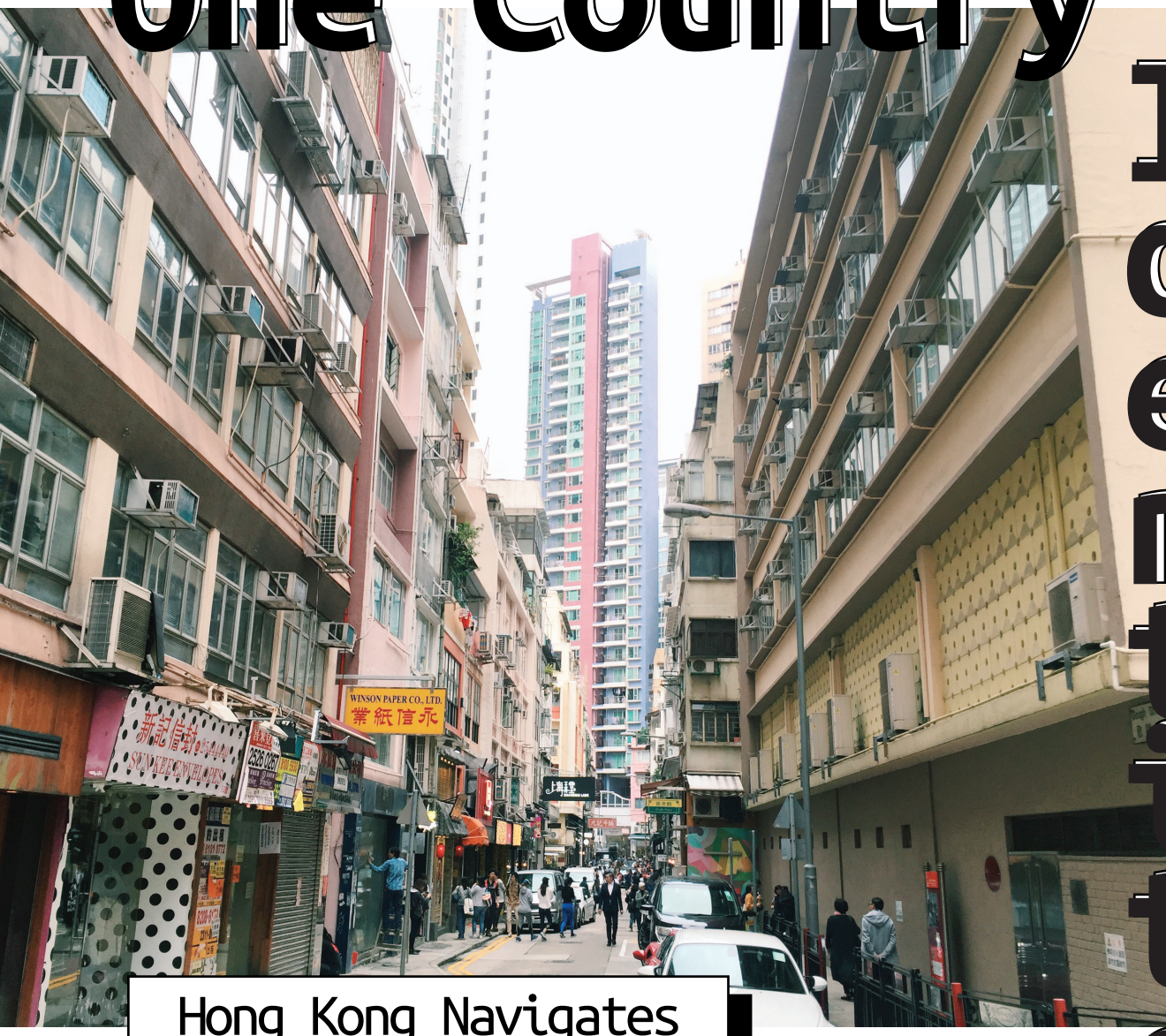
"Because there's a huge amount that's needed in terms of innovation, there's a huge amount that's needed in terms of policy, there's a huge amount that's needed in terms of financing, and all of those things will happen. They'll happen. If the political will is there," he continued.

On Tuesday January 24, four days into his presidency, Donald Trump signed an executive order allowing construction on the controversial Keystone XL and Dakota Access pipelines to continue. The Associated Press reported that Trump also ordered a "temporary media blackout" at the EPA and a halt on all its new contracts and grants.

But activists still see a path forward for climate change action under a Trump administration.

"I mean I'm hopeful," said Schweitzer. "There's a lot to be done. And I mean, we gotta do it, we've just got to. Right? There's not an option."

One Country Two Identities



Hong Kong Navigates an Uncertain Future

BY **SARAH STROBER**

"HERE, WE HAVE A SAYING," my 27-year-old tour guide whispered to me as he leaned across the table. "The mountains are high and the emperor is far away."

As I walked around Hong Kong over winter break, I saw few overt signs of Hong Kong's struggle to maintain democracy under an "emperor" in Beijing. But a landmark of the harbor is a large Communist flag plastered on the main government building. Its placement reminds those looking up that Hong Kong remains a semi-autonomous region within China.

In 1997, the United Kingdom handed over Hong Kong to China on the condition that for at least fifty years, it would maintain a "One Country, Two Systems" policy. Under this policy, Hong Kong is part of China. But Hong Kong's constitution, the Basic Law, grants the region a great deal of autonomy and guarantees citizens certain democratic rights, like the rights to free speech and freedom of the press.

Young people, like my tour guide, have conflicting identities: the Chinese government would identify them as Chinese, but they all insisted to me that they are "Hong Kong-ese." A Yale sophomore from China, who agreed to speak with *The Politic* on the condition of anonymity, also noted this conflict over identity.

"Interestingly, mainlanders seem to have the impression that most Hong Kong students introduce themselves as coming from Hong Kong rather than from China, which some regard as a sign of identity differentiation," she said.

The most dramatic public expression of Hong Kong-ese identity came a month before my visit.

Before taking office, all of Hong Kong's elected lawmakers must pledge to "bear allegiance to the Hong Kong Special Administrative Region of the People's Republic of China." Earlier this year, two young pro-independence lawmakers, Sixtus Leung, 30, and Yau Wai-ching, 25, altered the oath to protest Beijing's interference in Hong Kong's government.

In an interview with *The Politic*, Richard Bush, a senior fellow at the Brookings Institute, explained that since the Umbrella Revolution in 2014, a pro-democracy demonstration that lasted 79 days, dissenters have faced a crackdown.

"The only way to voice opposition is to engage in various types of protests of the symbolic sort," he said. "Making up one's oath is an example of that."

Rather than allow the Hong Kong courts to determine whether the lawmakers could take office, China's central court took direct action. Beijing interpreted the Basic Law to mean that legislators had to say the oath clearly, with no added allusions to independence. Hong Kong's high court then used this interpretation to ban the legislators from office.

The court's decision sparked wide-scale protests led by many of the same young visionaries who led the Umbrella Revolution.

The central court's unexpected review called into question whether Hong Kong's independent court had bowed to pressure from the mainland government.

Sophie Richardson, China Director at Human Rights Watch, explained to *The Politic* that Beijing's requirement that lawmakers properly recite an oath was not troubling on its own.

Rather, she said, "Our primary concern about the episode was actually that Beijing effectively weighed in before the courts of Hong Kong had even had a chance to hear the case properly."

Rana Mitter, Professor of the History and Politics of Modern China at the University of Oxford, agreed.

"The bigger question, and the one that people will really look at with some interest," he told *The Politic*, "is whether or not there is genuinely any eating away of the autonomy of Hong Kong's legislative and judicial procedures."

"If foreign companies, or foreign residents, or indeed Chinese Hong Kong residents felt that there was actually going to be any kind of impairment to the currently accepted, rather rigorous, rule of law in Hong Kong, that could create problems for the future," he continued.

The Basic Law constitution forms the basis of Hong Kong's identity, but after it expires in 2047, many of the freedoms Hong Kong residents have enjoyed are no longer assured. The question is what will happen once the fifty-year agreement ends.

In 2011, Danny Gittings, associate professor of constitutional law at Hong Kong University, wrote that there is "no reason necessarily to expect [Hong Kong in] 2047 to be any different [than Hong Kong] under the current system." But now he calls his own prediction "foolhardy."

In the last several years, Gittings' views have become increasingly pessimistic. In his book Introduction to Hong Kong's Basic Law, Gittings writes that Hong Kong has moved from a period from 1997–2003 of "maximum autonomy" to one from 2003–2014 of "closer monitoring and cautious involvement" to currently one in which "the central government is more directly involved."

"Some do believe that the 'One Country, Two Systems' policy will not last until 2047," he wrote, but he was careful to note that he does not agree with that claim.

Benny Tai, professor of law at Hong Kong University, thinks that change will come much earlier.

"I think a more important thing to look at is what may happen to China before 2047," he said in an interview with *The Politic*. "There is a chance that long before 2047 in the coming years, major change may happen in China that the future of Hong Kong will inevitably link with that."

"The most important thing we need to do in Hong Kong is to prepare

> "If nothing changes, 2047 will mark China's
> grip on the chain it binds Hong Kong with

for that moment, good or bad," he said.

"I'd say the feeling of the citizens of Hong Kong was a combined sense of resolution and empowerment over China, and a sense of desperation and disappointment," Hong Kong native Hana Davis '16 told *The Politic*.

In Hong Kong, she said, "I think there is a general sense of apprehension for 2047, and a feeling of hope – that perhaps, everyone's efforts won't be in vain and that something beneficial to Hong Kong's democracy will come."

"I think that if nothing changes, 2047 will mark China's tightened grip on the chain it binds Hong Kong with. Hong Kong will cease to be legally separate. Although the 'One Country, Two Systems' system may remain," Davis said, "[Hong Kong] will definitely be under total control and censorship of China."

Bush weighed the options for Hong Kong after 2047.

"You have to look at the consequences on one hand of keeping the Basic Law and trying to muddle through, or changing it so that the relationship between Hong Kong and the central government is tighter than it is now, which might create even more turbulence than they have now," he explained.

Angus Fong '19 took part in the Umbrella Revolution. Like Davis, Fong believes Beijing is taking greater control of Hong Kong.

"Clearly China is tightening its grip on Hong Kong and we have less room for freedom, less ammunition to decide how we want to live our lives," he told *The Politic*. "I suppose by 2047 it might just be another city in China."

Fong added that part of protecting Hong Kong's autonomy means finding common ground with the Chinese government. "Right now we don't know for sure what will happen,"

tightened
n."

he said, "but it's all about using the awareness of what is going on and people starting to listen to each other and figuring out what we all want in common."

Bush believes that the pro-democracy parties made some fatal errors several years ago that prevented them from achieving their legislative goals. He said the upcoming election for chief executive could have been "truly competitive" if pro-democracy forces had agreed with the Hong Kong government's election reform proposal in April of 2015.

"If the democratic side had been smart in who they picked as their possible candidate to run in the election, that person would have probably gotten through the process and named by the nominating committee as candidate," he said.

"The radicals who had been in power due to some of Beijing's tactics wanted to stay in the driver's seat of the democratic camp and they basically intimated their moderate colleagues into opposing the proposal," he continued.

As a result, Bush believes that the protesters may now "be opposing for the sake of opposing."

Mitter emphasized the importance of compromise.

"Ideas of Hong Kong independence are not going to be feasible," he said. "And therefore the importance of trying to find a way in which democracy can be preserved while working with Beijing is important."

Fong said that most people in Hong Kong are not expecting full independence from China.

"China is economically dependent on Hong Kong, but Hong Kong is even more economically dependent on China," he explained. He believes the protests are "less about full independence and more about sustaining our way of life." He continued, "All this culture we have built so far, we don't want it to just go away."

Despite the widespread pessimism, some efforts to preserve Hong Kong's culture have been successful.

"There have been examples in the last twenty years of protests having a positive effect in slowing what some people call 'mainlandization,' preserving Hong Kong's differences," Jeffrey Wasserstrom, Professor of History at University of California, Irvine, told *The Politic*.

He pointed to pro-democracy protests in 2003.

"There were plans for a new sort of laws on sedition, like the Patriot Act, that would try and control things in Hong Kong. Big protests led the Hong Kong authorities to table that," he said. However, he added, "In the recent past though it does seem like protests have much more of an uphill battle."

"You see a much more punitive response to certain kinds of response or protest," Richardson agreed.

As a result, she said, "I think some of the kinds of activists or independent protesters now think twice about whether they are going to be surveilled or prosecuted, whether there is going to be a larger negative consequence for trying to exercise those rights."

In addition to protests, foreign intervention is another method of pushing China to uphold Hong Kong's democracy.

Bush emphasized the importance of foreign diplomats in raising Hong Kong's democratic status in discussions with the Chinese.

"Instead of mentioning it tenth in the order of things or not mentioning it at all, they can mention it first or second and say, 'Americans are going to be watching what you do in Hong Kong, so don't screw it up." he said.

The anonymous Yale sophomore from China sees hope in the next generation to build understanding between Hong Kong and the mainland.

"I think that our generation may be more informed about Hong Kong's political situation because of more travel opportunities and the spread of the Internet," she said.

Wasserstrom was dubious.

"I think sometimes we overestimate how much exposure to different kinds of information will necessarily alter views," he said.

"There is a very strong influence of nationalistic propaganda, communication, and education on the mainland, that it takes a lot to unsettle some of those ideas," he explained. "There is also the possibility of it just escalating into more of a misunderstanding between people on two sides of a divide."

For protesters, the fight to keep Hong Kong's spirit alive is far from over.

"We continue to organize more Hong Kong people to fight for the autonomy of Hong Kong," Joshua Wong, a leader of the Hong Kong pro-democracy party Demosisto said in an interview with *The Politic*.

As the twentieth anniversary of Hong Kong's handover to China approaches this year, Demosisto has a plan. Wong explained, "It's necessary for us to generate a huge strike through the civil disobedience and to let the Chinese government know that it's time to give Hong Kong people back democracy."

FROM STOCKHOLM TO SEATTLE: FROM DC TO PHILADELPHIA: FROM NYC TO SAN FRANCISCO: FROM JONESBOROUGH TO HARTFORD:

A WOMEN'S MARCH ON WASHINGTON

BY **LINA VOLIN** & **OLIVIA PASCHAL**

A SEA OF PINK HATS and posters greeted Yalies as they poured out of charter buses and cars in Washington D.C. on January 21 — and that was just the line for the Metro. As students made their way to the National Mall, the crowd of people assembling for the Women's March on Washington steadily swelled. At each intersection, streams of pussy-hatted protesters joined the crowd from all directions, marching toward the Capitol less than 24 hours after President Donald Trump was inaugurated on its steps.

Far from Independence Avenue, in cities and towns from Stockholm, Sweden to Jonesborough, Tennessee, Yale students joined a series of sister marches expressing solidarity with each other and their displeasure with the new president on his first day. Chants for justice and equality rang to the tune of over three million protesters worldwide. Photos from each march are strikingly similar: pink hats and loud posters overwhelm jam-packed streets. Though the pictures are from marches across the globe, without distinctive landmarks you'd be hard-pressed to tell which march they came from. Their messages were the same: support women, dump Trump.

Victoria Hewlett '19, who attended the Women's March in Jonesborough, Tennessee, said that it was one of the largest activist gatherings she had ever seen in her region.

"While I've been to many activist rallies in the Tri-Cities [of Northeastern Tennessee], this march was more than twice the size of any I've been to — local press estimated the turnout to be more than 1,000," she told *The Politic*. "In one of the most consistently conservative regions in the state and nation, it was great for all of us to know that leftists have a vibrant local base committed to advancing our visions for the future of our community and nation."

But the March wasn't without its controversies. Organizers in many cities drew criticism from the right for excluding pro-life feminists and from the left for failing to promote an intersectional approach to feminism.

"It was the hugest crowd I've ever been a part of, but very tame," said Jackie Salzinger '18, who attended the Women's March in Seattle, Washington. "I would actually say too tame for my tastes. In typical Northwest fashion, no one really wanted to bother anyone else, least of all the upper middle class white women that dominated the scene, so trying to start up chants to keep up energy was mostly fruitless," she said.

Despite the criticism, the momentum following the March has continued to pressure the Trump administration in the form of issue-based advocacy and further protests, channeling the same combination of frustration and hope that drove protesters to the streets on January 21.

"It was heartening to see so many people, many of whom I assume have never gotten out like this for a political event, voicing their discontent and willingness to question the new status quo," said Salzinger.

SAN FRANCISCO, CA
JULIE LEONG ‘15

HARTFORD, CT
NICHOLAS GIRARD ‘19

STOCKHOLM, SWEDEN
ALICE OH ‘19

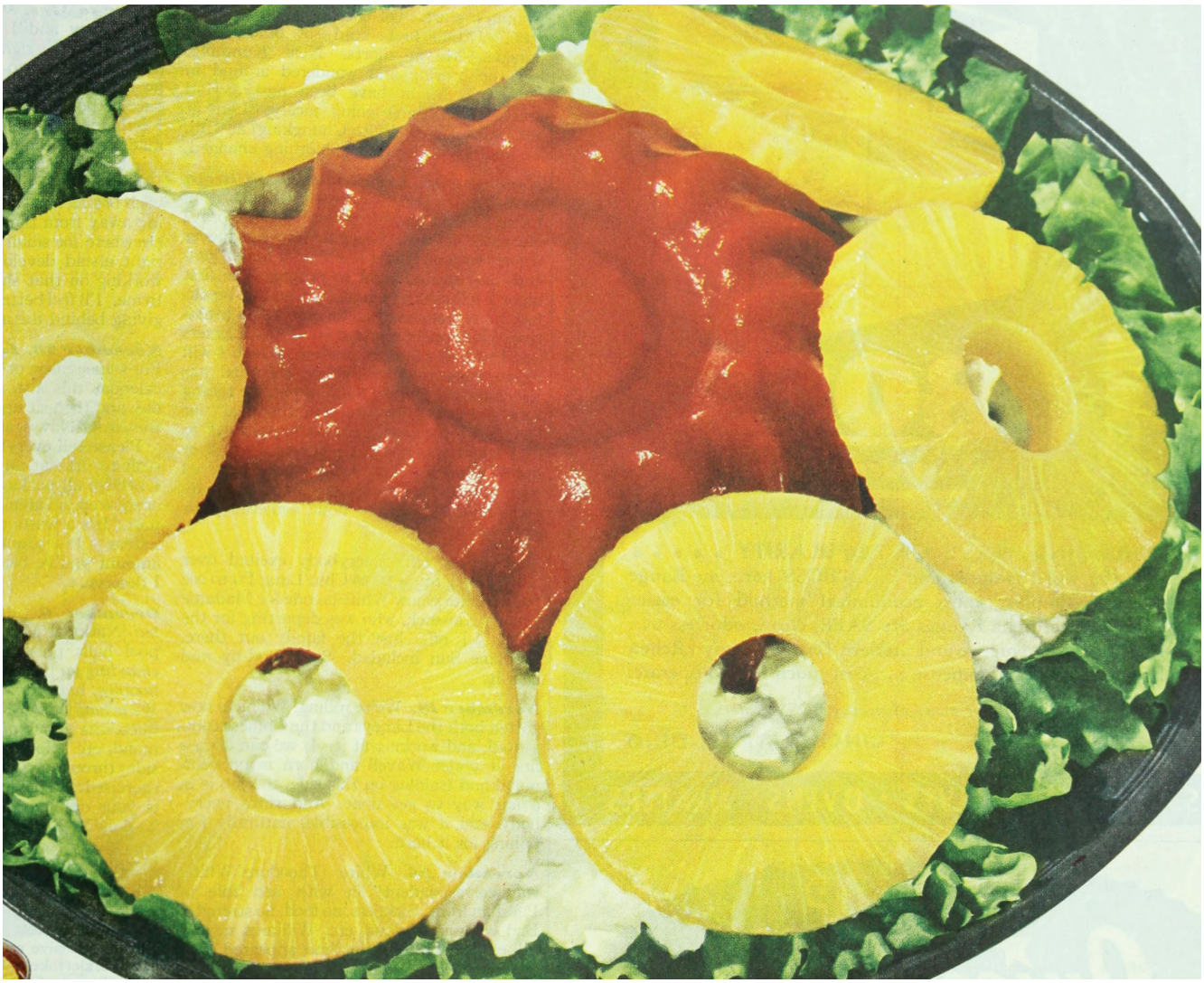
JONESBOROUGH, TN
VICTORIA HEWLETT ‘19

PHILADELPHIA, PA
CATHERINE YANG ‘19

WASHINGTON, DC
SANOJA BHAUMIK ‘19

WASHINGTON, DC
SANOJA BHAUMIK '19

NEW YORK CITY, NY
ANGELINA XING '17



OLD LIKE YELLOW PEARLS: THE STRUGGLE OF CHINA'S LEFTOVER WOMEN

SARINA XU

"ARE FEMALE PHD'S REALLY SO BAD TO MARRY?"

One user asked on a popular Chinese Internet forum. "They are unscrupulous, hypocritical, filthy, and weak," another commented in response. Many of the other comments expressed similar sentiments.

Yang Xu is a successful divorce court judge in Beijing. She is one of many women in China with graduate degrees who face this stereotype everyday. Now thirty-three and married, Yang Xu has not forgotten how hard it was to find a husband. "I find it ironic that I had to suffer consequences for deciding to gain an education beyond my bachelor's degree," she explained in an interview with *The Politic*. After attaining her law degree, Xu spent years as a practicing attorney. Meanwhile, those her own age were already getting married. But men didn't think Xu a suitable wife – she was too educated, according to her married friends.

Traditional Confucian ideas have historically limited women. This thinking shifted in the early days of the People's Republic of China, founded in 1949, when the Communist Party encouraged education for women. Mao Zedong famously called on women to "hold up half the sky" by going to school and joining the workforce. As a result, high school and university enrollment for girls substantially increased from 1949 to 1981.

But restrictions remain. In a book titled Revolution Postponed, author Margery Wolf demonstrates that although life has improved for Chinese women, gender equality has not been achieved. Traditional themes of domesticity and obedience remain relevant to daily life for women. They derive from a time in which a woman was expected to obey her father until she married, and then obey her husband. If she became a widow, she was expected to devote herself to her son. It was unthinkable that a woman

SINCE THE 1980S AND 1990S, CHINA HA
ROGRESSIVE REFORMS, AND COMPANIES W
ICES ARE RESURFACING.

would have a higher level of education than her husband.

Despite public efforts at transitioning China towards greater gender parity, highly educated women face several disadvantages, especially when it comes to marriage. A well-known article published by the All-China Women's Federation introduced the concept of a "yellowed pearl." The article reads: "Pretty girls do not need a lot of education to marry into a rich and powerful family... Girls with an average or ugly appearance... hope to further their education in order to increase their competitiveness. The tragedy is they don't realize that, as women age, they are worth less and less, so by the time they get their M.A. or PhD, they are already old, like yellowed pearls." With these stereotypes on display, international media led a storm of public criticism.

The yellowed pearl concept draws support from the well-documented, negative correlation between higher degrees like PhDs and marital status. The people who fall into this category are often known as shengnu, which translates as "leftover women."

In an interview with *The Politic*, Melissa Schneider, who wrote The Ugly Wife Is a Treasure at Home: True Stories of Love and Marriage in Communist China, states that a shengnu is widely understood to be any unmarried women over age 27, and "the epithet is a feared one among today's young Chinese women." This term is associated with women who have achieved an advanced education, but she explained, shengnu is "more about being unmarried than highly educated." To escape the fear of being "a yellowed pearl," 80 percent of Chinese women marry by age 25.

Many people in Chinese society today recognize three "genders": male, female, and female PhD. This last label, regularly used in conversation, refers to women who are smart, successful, wealthy — but still unmarried — at 28. Chinese media outlets regularly stereotype these women as aloof, unattractive, and self-driven careerists.

"Women are seen primarily as these reproductive entities, having babies for the good of the nation," said Leta Hong Fincher, author of the book Leftover Women: The Resurgence of Gender Inequality in China in an interview with Quartz.

The gendered double standard originates in the perceived conflict between women with graduate degrees and the family-centric priorities of the Communist state.

Deng, a 27-year-old sociology PhD candidate from the southern province of Hunan, explained this phenomenon as "a joke that means we're asexual and not feminine enough." During one interaction, she told Quartz, a worker was shocked to learn that she was working towards a PhD and exclaimed, "You're not bad looking even though you're a PhD."

An online user posted in Weibo, a Chinese microblogging website: "Female PhD's are the tragedy of China's leftover women." According to an online poll on Weibo, 30 percent of over 7,000 voters said they would not marry a [Chinese] woman with a PhD.

Xiao Wang, a blogger who graduated from the University of Leeds with a PhD in Chemistry, seemed more bemused than offended.

"Everyone believes that women with PhDs are a kind of third gender or third type of people. It overwhelms many people. I don't believe in the idea of this third type of person," she said. "I myself do not feel that my life is different from the lives of other people. The only difference is the environment I live and work in," she blogged.

More than anything, Xiao Wang is puzzled why so many people are unwilling to marry highly educated women. "I feel that love is just a matter

AS DISMANTLED MANY OF ITS EARLIER PR
WITH MORE CONSERVATIVE HIRING PRACTI

of fate, these things cannot be deliberately forced," she wrote.

This sexist situation stems from the tradition of female hypergamy, which is common throughout China. Hypergamy is the tendency to marry a person of higher social status. Although most Chinese newlyweds, like couples elsewhere, are of similar age and education, it is also quite common for Chinese women to marry men who are better educated than they are, while men typically marry women who are less educated.

According to the calculations of PhD candidate Yue Qian of Ohio State University, 55 percent of university-educated Chinese men marry a less educated spouse, whereas only 32 percent of university-educated women do the same. Melissa Schneider argues that when it comes to education, A-quality men will find B-quality women; B-quality guys will find C-quality women; and C-quality men will find D-quality women — so those left are A-quality women and D-quality men.

Chinese registered psychologist and expert Liu Fuliang weighed in on why men are unwilling to marry women with PhDs. In an article translated by EChinaCities she states, "Men regard women with PhDs as having one set of specific 'stereotypical' characteristics. They see them as a third gender with either a strange temperament or an excessive drive to succeed. Chinese men traditionally see the ideal woman as gentle, soft and virtuous."

In recent years, highly educated Chinese women have emerged on the national and world stage as powerful players. According to Forbes magazine, 11 of the 20 richest self-made women in the world are Chinese, and now 19 percent of Chinese women in management positions are CEOs, which is the second highest percentage worldwide. This social transition and the undeniable rise of women in China is captured in the phrase: yin-sheng, yang-shuai, which means that the female (yin) is on the up, while the male (yang) is on the way down.

Chinese men also feel the pressure to marry. Popular belief states that if a man and his family cannot buy property, he will struggle to find a bride. So mortgages often precede marriages. When choosing a husband, three-quarters of women consider his ability to provide a home, based on a recent survey in China's coastal cities by Horizon China, a Beijing market-research firm. Even if a woman dismisses this point, her family and friends will often remind her of it.

Men spend dutifully on property to improve their position in the marriage queue. But such a mindset forces other men to spend more in response. Unmarried men are locked in a Darwinian race where overpriced and ostentatious homes symbolize what only the wealthiest males can boast.

Hong Fincher explains that "home ownership defines masculinity" in her interview with Quartz. Often a couple's finances are arranged so that the husband can take all the pride of owning the home, even if in reality his wife jointly supports the household. A dutiful wife may feel obliged to bolster this superficial mask of masculinity.

The idea of "leftover women" harms women and men in China. For men, there is intense pressure to assert their masculinity. And for women, education becomes a barrier to marriage. As more of China's women pursue advanced degrees, tensions between traditional ideas and modern women will only grow. The question is whether Chinese society can adjust.

People, Not Numbers

What Wisconsin Knew that Pollsters Didn't

BY **JACOB MALINOWSKI**

EVERY WISCONSINITE KNOWS two names: Aaron Rodgers, quarterback for the Green Bay Packers, and Scott Walker, the governor of the state. Rodgers has roused loyal Packers fans by leading the team to a Super Bowl victory and this year's NFC championship game. Walker, who ran for president but dropped out before the Iowa caucuses, also has mobilized Wisconsin Republicans to overcome long odds — from his own recall election victory in 2012 to Trump's 2016 presidential election results.

Rodgers' roles in fun commercials for local insurance companies make him seem relatable and normal; Walker publicly praises his Harley-Davidson motorcycle and jokes about his embarrassing jean shorts — but not to the same effect. While Rodgers enjoys an 80 percent approval rating as he smashes his rivals, Walker's consistent pummeling of state Democrats only earns him 38 percent favorability. The governor has picked fights on highly partisan issues — unions, voter identification, and women's healthcare — that have made him a divisive figure in the statewide political discussion. Though Packers' fans would do anything to keep Rodgers, it remains

unclear whether they'll embrace Walker too.

Wisconsin made waves in the recent presidential election as it went red for the first time in over thirty years, giving all ten of its electoral votes to Donald Trump. The rural areas of the state, controlled by Republicans for decades, provide a strong conservative base. But Wisconsin's liberal cities usually have high voter turnout, which strikes a balance within the state. This equilibrium will face its next test in 2018 when the governor's office is on the ballot. Though Walker has not officially announced a bid for reelection, many suspect he will run again. If Democrats want to stand up to Republicans in Wisconsin, this election is a must-win.

Perhaps most interesting about Wisconsin politics is that the experts always seem wrong. Newspapers said Walker would lose the recall election and polls on the presidential election showed Hillary Clinton ahead for the entire race. Wisconsin defied both of these expectations — and people in Wisconsin will tell you they knew it all along. To find where Wisconsin is headed, I went back to my birthplace and talked to my fellow Cheeseheads. Hearing these people's stories, I thought, would be the best way to measure the political climate of America's Dairyland.

Linda and Lonni Ramazini-Zahn were wearing Rodgers jerseys on the plane back home to Milwaukee, Wisconsin on Tuesday, December 20. As the plane took off, we talked about the game from the previous Sunday, where the Packers narrowly beat their divisional rival, the Chicago Bears, to keep their playoff hopes alive. Linda expressed pessimism about the team's chances in the upcoming games. Lonni disagreed.

"People always seem to get Wisconsin wrong. Nobody gives us enough credit — underdogs or not," Lonni explained.

Lonni is a foreman for a construction company. He's been working his way up the chain of command for thirty years, and it shows in the wrinkles on his knuckles and the deep lines on his palms. He said he's tired every day after work, but he can "really see the fruits of his labor." The construction job provides him with enough money to live comfortably, but the work can go as quickly as it comes. He never went to college.

"School wasn't for me. At the time, that was no big deal. Nowadays, though, I'm not sure. People look at you differently," Lonni reflected.

"People look at you differently because you're a crabby old man, Lon," Linda retorted. Linda works as a manager at Sherwin-Williams; she says paint "runs in her blood".

"Life isn't as bad as people outside make it out to be. We work hard, we pay our taxes, we go to church," she said.

Linda spoke at length about her family over the past ten years. Her voice, which was cheerful and energetic before, seemed to sink as she recalled times of illness and unemployment.

"They worked in a circle. Someone would lose their job, then get sick, and then never be able to get another job because they were always sick," she lamented.

And things never changed. Linda did not mention who she voted for back in 2008, but she did allude to "having hope in something new." But this hope, she said, went unfulfilled.

"It's difficult, you know, to make it by? This whole thing with healthcare: it doesn't seem to work. The Democrats say one thing and the Republicans say another thing, but all I'm seeing is our costs go up. It doesn't matter who's right and wrong to me," Linda said.

Lonni noticed a similar pattern. He recalled his first years with his new

company. He was getting promotions ahead of those who had been there for much longer and who knew "much more than he ever did."

"I'd talk to these guys and ask why they never wanted to be a project manager or a foreman. Why didn't they put in just a little extra work, you know? And I always got the same answer: they didn't care," Lonni said.

Lonni said his frustration was with the apathy. Plenty of young kids showed up on his worksite, he told me, and they were just there to get the money. He said there was no motivation or inspiration to do anything more.

"So why are my tax dollars going to help people like that? I'm not angry and I'm not a racist. I'm really trying to do what's best for my family," Lonni explained.

I asked them about a few of then-President-elect Donald Trump's remarks, both during and after the campaign. Linda scowled. Lonni shook his head.

"Hear me out: I don't agree with most of that, right? But I didn't hear a whole lot else. I had to turn off the debates after a while. I just couldn't keep track," Lonni said.

"It's so difficult nowadays to really see what [the candidates] believe in and what's true or not. [Hillary Clinton] just didn't say things I really believed. She seemed so untrustworthy," Linda added.

She clarified she didn't really like Trump; she was reluctant to vote for him. Her husband agreed.

"I'm not set on voting for him again. He's not my favorite guy. When elections roll around again, I'll do my best to figure out who is going to be best for me," Lonni added.

I reminded them about the 2018 elections in Wisconsin. Walker's announcement about his reelection campaign is expected once the 2017 budget is submitted.

"I'm a big Walker fan," commented Lonni. "He's been a great governor so far — voted for him every time."

"My whole family votes for Walker. He's normal and he gets things done, unlike [former Wisconsin governor Jim Doyle], and we really need someone who understands the balance," Linda said.

Walker's Democratic competitor is currently unknown. With Walker defeating various opponents through multiple elections, including the historic 2012 recall election, the Democratic bench has taken a hit. Milwaukee mayor Tom Barrett is one option, but he has already suffered two losses to Walker. Other potential names include former Wisconsin State Senator Tim Cullen and Dane County Executive Joe Parisi.

As the Ramazini-Zahns said, apathy can be the real killer in Wisconsin politics. Democrats may be weak because there is little to stir the base; outreach efforts have slowed, and the election results have left many Wisconsinites dejected.

But some Wisconsin residents are incredibly enthusiastic about state politics. A man who would only give the name "Dave" spoke about his enthusiasm for Trump.

"He was the best candidate. I campaigned furiously as soon as it was clear he was serious," Dave said.

Dave added that few people "suspect" him of being a Trump supporter. If it comes up in conversation, he'll mention it, but he said he doesn't "look the part."

"When people think 'rural Trump voter', they don't think of me," Dave explained, "I don't wear camo, I don't have an accent, I don't say hateful things."

Dave said he works at a local marketing firm, which is where he met his wife. Both are Wisconsin natives, which was evident from the cow keychain proudly displayed on his key ring. Dave is soft-spoken, and he talked slowly, like he was meticulously choosing the next word to leave his mouth. His face was hidden behind his coffee mug as he sipped and listened to my question, but

quickly lit up as he gave answers.

Dave said his primary concern is for his children, both of whom are very young. He showed worn pictures of them in his wallet.

"There's gotta be a good world for them. I'm worried about my family and what kind of America they're going to grow up in," Dave explained.

Dave said he believed Trump was his best bet for the future. Trump's vision and message convinced him that America could be fixed.

"I'm more passionate about ideas. Clinton didn't have any. I had heard them all before. Trump was a different candidate, someone who knows how to build a business, and I think that can transfer over to the presidency," Dave said.

"Those polls and analysts can all say whatever they want, but they need to start looking at a smaller level. We're people, not numbers."

Yet his opinion on Walker differed sharply.

"Walker is destroying Wisconsin. We lose jobs; he strips away union power. Our state budget won't balance. He takes away money from schools. Doesn't make sense to me," said Dave.

Dave criticized the Democratic party's efforts in Wisconsin. He said he noticed that the Republican party used many local mobilization strategies that the Democratic party seemed to overlook.

And Dave's critique isn't unique. Clinton faced routine questions about her lack of campaign stops in Wisconsin and other states in the final weeks of the campaign. Some even said it was misguided for her to try to capture typically Republican states instead of working to maintain the Democratic-leaning ones.

Dave remarked that he saw her loss coming all along.

"As soon as she stopped coming up here, I knew it was over. Those polls and analysts can all say whatever they want, but they need to start looking at a smaller level. We're people, not numbers," he explained.

These generalizations don't only harm Trump supporters in Wisconsin; Democrats feel the pain too. Heather Huber of Wausau feels snubbed as a Wisconsin Democrat.

"When they thought the state was Democratic, we were ignored. Now, after this election, it seems like the party gave up. We can't win either way," Huber said.

Huber went to a local college and now works as a business manager in Wisconsin. She said she's been a Democrat for life, and was seriously disappointed with both Clinton and her Senate candidate Russ Feingold, who also lost to incumbent Ron Johnson.

"I'm not really sure where it all went wrong. Everybody was saying we had it in the bag. I still don't know what caused it all," Huber said.

She said her confusion was not unique – many of her colleagues discussed the results with disbelief the following day. Huber also said she could not fathom how many of her fellow Wisconsinites voted for Trump.

"It just doesn't make sense to me. Nobody I talked to liked the guy. He said crazy things — hurtful, too — and I didn't think people here were like that," Huber added.

Huber said her passion for the Democratic Party was inspired by its core belief in equity. She explained she had grown up in a very poor neighborhood. Her gaze wandered as she described her childhood home: A roof — and a family — falling apart.

“It seems like journalists came in and studied us. Like we’re animals. Or aliens. How can people who only live a few states away treat me like a different species?”

“I climbed out of there, and lots of Republicans want everyone to do the same thing. I’m here to tell you that not everyone can do it. Not because they don’t want to, but because something is in their way. Just not fair, I guess,” Huber explained.

Huber apologized immediately after making that remark. She said that labelling people without getting to know them is troublesome. Expressing frustration with some of the news articles written about her home state, she was initially hesitant to answer my questions.

“It seems like journalists came in and studied us. Like we’re animals. Or aliens. They published all these articles about ‘investigating Trump’s America’ or ‘exploring the Midwest’ and it made me uncomfortable,” she said. “How can people who only live a few states away treat me like a different species?”

Despite this, Huber thinks local elections might be most important in changing how Wisconsin operates. She suspects 2018 will be an important year. While she’s not exactly sure who will run against Walker, Huber resolves to more actively support the Democrats.

“Even if I get frustrated or angry, I know I have to be productive. If [the Democratic Party] can get a good candidate, I’ll do whatever it takes. Everybody has to. If we can do that, maybe 2020 will be different,” Huber said.

Wisconsin has a long time to wait until 2018, but that doesn’t mean the process will slow down. As the snow melts, yard signs will sprout from the earth like the flowers of spring. The excitement of football games will be replaced with political advertisements, and political talk will descend upon Wisconsin and sweep through the population like a pandemic, infecting arguments for months to come. While uncertainty lingers, one fact rings true:

“This whole state could go to shit, but if I’m watching the Packer game on a Sunday afternoon, nothin’ else really matters,” Lonni said with a smile.

on-line pre-view

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Breaking Down Identity Politics: The Rationale of an Atypical Trump Supporter

Sabrina Bustamante ('20) talks to a voter who doesn't fit into the rural white working class mold about why he cast his ballot for President Donald Trump, and what his hopes are for the new administration.

Outsourcing Propaganda: China's Control Over Hollywood

Adding movie theaters at a record rate, China will soon top the United States as the world's largest film market. Alex Posner ('18) takes us behind the scenes as he explores how Hollywood producers have responded to a growing Chinese audience.

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An enduring commitment of the MacMillan Center is to enable students to spend time abroad to undertake research and other academically-oriented, international and area studies-related activities. Each year it supports Yale students with nearly $4 million in funding to pursue their research interests.

The MacMillan Center is also home to the Fox International Fellowship, a graduate student exchange program between Yale and 19 of the world's leading universities in Africa, Asia, Australia, Europe, the Middle East, and the Americas. Its goal is to enhance mutual understanding between the peoples of the United States and other countries by promoting international scholarly exchanges and collaborations among the next generation of leaders.

Special Events

The MacMillan Center extracurricular programs deepen and extend this research-teaching nexus of faculty and students at Yale, with more than 700 lectures, conferences, workshops, roundtables, symposia, film, and art events each year. Virtually all of these are open to the community at large. Its annual flagship lectures, the Coca-Cola World Fund Lecture and the George Herbert Walker, Jr. Lecture in International Studies, bring a number of prominent scholars and political figures to the Yale campus.

The MacMillan Report

The MacMillan Center produces *The MacMillan Report*, an Internet show that showcases Yale faculty in international and areas studies and their research in a one-on-one interview format. Webisodes can be viewed at macmillanreport.yale.edu.

YaleGlobal Online

This publication disseminates information about globalization to millions of readers in more than 215 countries around the world. *YaleGlobal* publishes original articles aimed at the wider public, authored by Yale faculty, world leaders, major foreign policy figures, and top specialists in politics, economics, diplomacy, business, health, and the environment.

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